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MUNDKUR, WHO USES
ART AS A THERAPEUTIC
TOOL, AT HER CLINIC

“ The Feldenkrais Method is used for the reduction of pain and to restore abilities while artistes like dancers and musicians use it to further their craft. ”

MICHEL CASSANOVAS, FM Practitioner

SANJAY RAMCHANDRAN//www.indiatodayimages.com

fact that there are not more than “a handful of known practitioners in India make the distinction unnecessary”, says Mundkur. The gap is evident from the figure. The American Art Therapy Association alone has a membership of 6,000 medical practitioners. While India might not have thousands of trained art therapists, yet it is heartening to note that hospitals and mental health institutions dealing with children are increasingly resorting to non-conventional tools like art and drama as tools to heal and manage patients.

India might be a treasure trove of classical arts, but still there's a dearth of research professionals who have applied arts and movement to create hybrid and complementary therapies. Though India has plenty of dance forms, it was only recently that these were being used as a therapy to help people overcome or deal with medical ailments and disabilities. “Everyone knows that dance and



CASSANOVAS CONDUCTS A SESSION

music are therapeutic but we have no training centres to help us understand the scientific nature of these therapies or know how to use them,” says Brinda Jacob, a trained dance therapist from the UK. Jacob was inspired by Tripura Kashyap, a trained dancer who did an advanced course in the subject from the Hancock Centre for Movement Therapy in the US and is a pioneer of dance therapy in India. On her return from the UK, Jacob set up The Studio for Movement Art and Therapies in Bangalore. Both Jacob and Kashyap work with special children as well as conduct workshops on dance therapy.

If art and dance can work as alternative therapies, music can't be far behind. The power of music for healing has been acknowledged even by the medical fraternity. Based on scientific research and studies on the healing effects of certain rhythms, the Svaram Musical Instruments Research Station was established at Auroville in Puducherry in 2003. The outcome of Svaram research is several healing sound instruments, one of which is the Nidranantar, a hollow wooden bed fixed with 50 strings underneath. The strings are tuned to two different frequencies decided upon earlier and the instrument is played by the therapist with a person lying on the bed. Kapila Ramakrishnan, therapist and healer, says, “Most people come to us because they are curious about the sound healing instrument. Then there are others who come to us for some specific ailment or problem. The sound vibrations caused by the strings help energy flows. Most problems, whether mental or physical, are caused by energy blocks and this, we believe, helps energy flow smoothly again. We recommend it as a complementary therapy,” says Ramakrishnan, who quit a flourishing career in the advertising industry to work in the field of alternative healing.

Whether used in a complementary or primary role, the growing popularity of alternative therapies may well point to a painless new age. ■